

GOLDEN MEMORIES

Meet three Olympic champions who **redefined greatness** and left an indelible mark on sports history. These athletes not only clinched gold but also inspired millions with their incredible feats.

Team Sportstar

KRISTIN OTTO

Never before had a female athlete won more than four gold medals at a single Games. At Seoul 1988, Otto took part in six events and won all of them with the utmost ease. Born in Leipzig, Otto was drafted into a specialised sports school when she was around 11 and made steady strides before becoming part of the East German world record-breaking quartet in the 400m medley relay at the 1982 world championships.

Two years later, she was supposed to make it big in Los Angeles before the boycott of the Games by the East European bloc countries spoiled her intended party. Later that year, as ill-luck would have it, she injured a vertebra, which forced her to remain in a neck brace for the next nine months. The medical team attending her insisted that Otto give up swimming, but she would have none of it and was back in the pool soon after.

At the 1986 worlds, Otto's steely determination brought her four golds in a bag of six. The European Championships next year saw an encore with five gold medals, after she opted out of the 50m freestyle. In Seoul, she tasted success in three different categories, competing in the 50m, the 100m freestyle, the 100m backstroke and the 100m butterfly, beside the two relays, to seal one of the most historic achievements of the Games.



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